

Intermediate State

doc-intermediate-state
Eschatology · Intermediate State · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Believers who die are immediately and consciously present with the Lord, at rest, awaiting bodily resurrection. Soul sleep (unconsciousness of the dead until resurrection) is rejected.

In plain language

The question asks whether believers who die are at once consciously present with the Lord, at rest, while they wait for bodily resurrection, and whether soul sleep, the idea that the dead are unconscious until resurrection, should be rejected. Two clusters of words stand in tension. The presence cluster in the New Testament pairs two household words at 2 Corinthians 5:8, one for being away from home, 'out of the body' (ekdemesai ek tou somatos), and one for being 'at home with the Lord' (endemesai pros ton kyrion), and sets them as one move with no unconscious gap named. Philippians 1:23 binds 'to depart' (analousai) and 'to be with Christ' (syn Christo einai) together as far better than staying alive. Luke 23:43 places 'today' (semeron) next to 'you will be with me in paradise' (ese en to paradeiso), and on the plain word order today times the being-with. The Revelation 6 'souls' (psychai) under the altar speak, ask how long, and are told to rest a little longer while still aware. The rich man and Lazarus picture the dead seeing, remembering, feeling, and talking, using the same 'soul' (psyche) language family. The sleep cluster in the Old Testament and New uses the verb 'to fall asleep' (koimaomai, Greek; yashen, Hebrew) for dead believers, and says the dead know nothing, and that in 'the realm of the dead' (Sheol) there is no remembrance, no praise. The soul sleep reading takes these as literal statements that the person is unconscious. The presence-cluster verbs are direct words for being with the Lord and use clear prepositional phrases of presence. The sleep-cluster terms are mostly euphemism for the body (since the same word in plain Greek already meant death in everyday speech) and lament from the living side, observing that the dead no longer take part in earthly worship and earthly knowledge. The early Greek manuscripts carry no punctuation, so the comma at Luke 23:43 is the editor's choice, which is a real but narrow opening. Because the New Testament directly names being with the Lord at death and the soul sleep texts read mostly as euphemism and phenomenology (description from observed appearance), the verdict tilts toward immediate conscious presence, but the Old Testament silence-formulae and the sleep vocabulary are real lexical witnesses on the other side, which is why confidence is medium rather than high.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H2142	זָכַר	zakhar	to remember	
H3045	יָדָעַם	yada	to know	
H3462	יָשָׁן	yashen	to sleep	16
H3463	יָשְׁנוּ	yashen	sleeping	
H4191	מָתַם	mut	to die	

H4194	τις,	mavet	death	
H6083	ἄσπις,	aphar	dust	
H7585	ἡλύω,	sheol	hell	66
G0086	ἄδης	hades	hell	10
G0360	ἀναλύω	analuo	to depart	2
G0931	βάσανος	basanos	torment	3
G1553	ἐκδημέω	ekdemeo	be away	3
G1736	ἐνδημέω	endemeo	be home	3
G2193	ἕως	heōs	until	
G2292	θαρρέω	tharreo	be confident	6
G2837	κοιμάομαι	koimaomai	to sleep	18
G2859	κόλπος	kolpos	bosom	6
G2896	ἐκκραζαν	krazō	to cry	
G3857	παράδεισος	paradeisos	paradise	3
G4594	σήμερον	sēmeron	today	
G4862	σὺν	sun	with	
G5590	ψυχή	psyche	soul	103

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two clusters of vocabulary stand in tension. The conscious-presence cluster pairs 'to be away from home, out of the body' (ekdemesai ek tou somatos) with 'to be at home with the Lord' (endemesai pros ton kyrion) at 2 Corinthians 5:8, joins 'to depart, to break camp' (analsai) to 'to be with Christ' (syn Christo einai) at Philippians 1:23, places 'today' (semeron) next to 'you will be with me in paradise' (ese en to paradeiso) at Luke 23:43, and shows post-mortem 'souls' (psychai) speaking, perceiving, and resting under the altar at Revelation 6:9-11 and in the Lazarus narrative at Luke 16:23. The soul-sleep cluster draws on 'to fall asleep' (koimaomai) applied to dead believers at 1 Thessalonians 4:13-15, the verb 'to sleep' (yashen) plus dust at Daniel 12:2, the wisdom statements that the dead know nothing at Ecclesiastes 9:5,10, and the 'realm of the dead' (Sheol) silence formulae at Psalm 6:5 and Psalm 115:17. The conscious-presence verbs are direct and pair explicit prepositional phrases of presence with the Lord, whereas the soul-sleep terms read mostly as death-euphemism (an everyday substitute word, like saying 'passed away') for the body and as phenomenological language (description from observed appearance, not from inside the experience) about the realm of the dead (Sheol) from the side of the living. The verdict therefore tilts toward immediate conscious presence, but the Old Testament silence-formulae and the 'fall asleep' (koimaomai) pattern are real lexical witnesses, so confidence remains medium and the question is genuinely contested at the word level.

Scripture

2Cor.5.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1553 ἐκδημῆσαι, G1736 ἐνδημῆσαι, G2292 θαρροῦμεν

Reasoning. Paul expresses 'we are confident' (tharroumen) and good pleasure rather to be away-from-home, 'out of the body' (ekdemesai ek tou somatos), and 'at-home with the Lord' (endemesai pros ton kyrion). The two 'completed past action' (aorist) infinitives form one coordinated move, a single transition leaving the body and arriving present with 'the Lord' (kyrios). The household verbs picture a relocation of the person, and the prepositional phrases 'out of the body' (ek tou somatos) and 'toward the Lord' (pros ton kyrion) mark origin and goal directly without naming any intermediate state of unconsciousness.

Phil.1.23 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0360 ἀναλῦσαι, G4862 σὺν

Reasoning. Paul is pressed between two, having the desire 'for the to depart and to be with Christ' (eis to analusai kai syn Christo einai), to depart and to be with Christ, which he judges 'much rather better' (pollo mallon kreisson). The 'completed past action' (aorist) infinitive 'to depart, to loose, to break camp' (analousai) pictures loosing or breaking camp, and is bound by 'and' (kai) to 'to be with Christ' (syn Christo einai) as one continuous prospect. The phrase 'to be with Christ' (syn Christo einai) uses the simple infinitive of presence with the dative-governing (a noun in the 'to-X' or 'with-X' grammatical form) preposition 'with' (syn), naming concurrent companionship, not a deferred reunion.

Luke.23.43 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4594 σήμερον, G3857 παραδείσω

Reasoning. 'Truly I say to you, today with me you will be in paradise' (Amen lego soi, semeron met emou ese en to paradeiso). The adverb 'today' (semeron) stands adjacent to 'you will be' (ese, the future second singular of the verb 'to be', eimi) and to 'in paradise' (en to paradeiso). On the natural word order 'today' (semeron) times the being-with-me-in-paradise. The early manuscripts transmit no punctuation, so the comma is editorial. The soul-sleep reading attaches 'today' (semeron) to 'I say' (lego), giving 'I say to you today, you will be with me in paradise', which is grammatically possible but lexically requires reading 'I say to you today' (lego soi semeron) as a Hebraism (a Hebrew-style phrasing carried into Greek) for solemn declaration, for which the Greek of Luke supplies no other clear parallel.

Luke.16.23 · for · genre: narrative · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2859 κόλποις, G0931 βασάνοις, G0086 ᾄδῃ

Reasoning. After death the rich man, 'in the realm of the dead, in torments' (en to hade en basanois), lifts his eyes, sees Abraham far off and Lazarus 'in his bosom' (en tois kolpois autou), and converses. The post-mortem figures perceive, remember, feel, and speak. The narrative pictures conscious experience immediately after death. As parable it teaches by depiction rather than as topographical reportage, so its weight is illustrative, but its vocabulary of 'soul' (psyche) language activity post-mortem is the same family the epistles use.

Rev.6.10 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: personification

Key terms. G5590 ψυχὰς, G2896 ἔκραξαν, G2193 ἕως

Reasoning. The 'souls' (psychai) of the slain under the altar 'cried out with a loud voice' (ekraxan phone megale), asking 'until when' (heos pote), how long, until they are vindicated, and are told 'they shall rest yet a little while' (anapausontai eti chronon mikron). The vocabulary attributes voice, perception, and ethical questioning to the disembodied 'souls' (psychai), and the rest motif here is rest-while-aware, not rest-as-unconsciousness, since the same souls are speaking in the verses immediately before.

1Thess.4.13 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2837 κοιμωμένων

Reasoning. Paul speaks of 'those who have fallen asleep' (koimomenoi), those who have fallen asleep, and frames the comfort around their bodily resurrection at 'the coming, the arrival' (parousia). The participle 'to fall asleep' (koimaomai) applied to dead believers can be heard as literal sleep of the person (soul-sleep reading) or as the standard Hellenistic euphemism (an everyday substitute word, like 'passed away') for death applied to the visible body (death-euphemism reading). The verb itself is lexically ambiguous between these senses; its surrounding context here speaks of the bodies being raised but does not adjudicate whether the person was conscious in the interval.

Eccl.9.5 · complicates · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4191 מתים, H3045 ידעים

Reasoning. 'The dead know not anything' (hammetim enam yodim meumah), the dead know not anything, and there is no more reward for them. Read by the soul-sleep position as a flat denial of post-mortem awareness. The wisdom genre and the recurring 'under the sun' (tachat hashshemesh) frame describe death from the vantage of the living under the sun, cataloguing what is no longer accessible to the dead with respect to earthly life, reward, love, hate. The verbs of 'knowing' (yada, here in the participle yodim) are phenomenological (described from observed appearance, not from inside the experience), observed from above, and the text does not explicitly address whether the person retains awareness in a different mode.

Ps.6.5 · complicates · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4194 מות, H7585 שאול, H2142 זכר

Reasoning. 'For in death there is no remembrance of you, in the realm of the dead who gives you thanks' (Ki en bammavet zikrekha, bisheol mi yodeh lakh), for in 'death' (mavet) there is no remembrance of you, in 'Sheol, the realm of the dead' (sheol) who gives you thanks. The Psalm is lament-speech pleading for deliverance from death. The argument is that praise of YHWH ceases from the realm of the dead toward the living covenant community. The lexical question is whether the silence is absolute about the dead person, or whether it describes the absence of cultic praise from 'Sheol, the realm of the dead' (sheol) toward the living world. Either reading is grammatically available; the genre is petition rather than ontology.

Dan.12.2 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H3463 ישני, H6083 עפר

Reasoning. 'Many of those sleeping in the dust of the earth shall awake' (Rabbim miyshenei admat aphar yaqitzu), many of those sleeping in the dust of the earth shall awake. The participle 'those sleeping' (yshenei) from the verb 'to sleep' (yashen) applied with 'dust of the earth' (admat aphar) locates the sleeping in the dust, the burial-place. The figure is bodily, the dust is the grave, and the awakening is bodily resurrection. The verse supplies sleep-of-the-body language without by itself supplying sleep-of-the-soul language, so it is lexically compatible with either lens, depending on whether 'to sleep' (yashen) is read as applying to the whole person or to the body.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Cor.5.8	Phil.1.23	tsk	1
2Cor.5.6	2Cor.5.1	tsk	1
Phil.1.23	2Tim.4.6	tsk	1
Luke.23.43	2Cor.12.4	openbible	2
Luke.23.43	Rev.2.7	openbible	2
Luke.16.22	Luke.16.23	tsk	1

Rev.6.9	Rev.20.4	openbible	1
1Thess.4.13	1Cor.15.20	tsk	1
Eccl.9.5	Ps.115.17	openbible	1
Dan.12.2	Isa.26.19	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Luke.23.43 · addressed

Soul-sleep readers move the comma so that 'today' (semeron) modifies 'I say' (lego), giving 'I say to you today, you will be with me in paradise', placing the being-with at an unspecified later time. The original manuscripts have no punctuation, so the dispute is editorial. The default reading attaches 'today' (semeron) to the immediate clause-mate 'you will be' (ese). The proposed Hebraism (a Hebrew-style phrasing carried into Greek) 'I say to you today' (lego soi semeron) as solemn-declaration formula has no clear parallel inside Luke. The complication is real but the lexical default favors immediate presence.

Eccl.9.5 · addressed

The dead know not anything and there is no more reward sit inside Qohelet's 'under the sun' (tachat hashshemesh) discourse, the under-the-sun perspective. Lexically 'to know' (yada) plus the negative describes loss of access to earthly knowledge and reward, not necessarily metaphysical unconsciousness. The text is wisdom-observation from the living side, and does not by itself foreclose conscious existence in another mode.

1Thess.4.13 · addressed

'To fall asleep' (koimaomai) applied to the dead in Christ is read by the soul-sleep position as literal sleep of the person. Lexically 'to fall asleep' (koimaomai) is the standard Hellenistic euphemism (an everyday substitute word, like 'passed away') for death applied to the visible bodily condition, attested broadly in non-Christian Greek before the New Testament. The verb itself is genuinely ambiguous between literal-sleep and death-euphemism senses, and the surrounding context here turns on bodily resurrection rather than on the awareness of the interval, so it does not settle the question alone.

Ps.115.17 · addressed

'The dead do not praise YH' (lo hammetim yehallu Yah), the dead do not praise YH, sits in a covenant-praise frame contrasting the living congregation that praises with the silent grave. Lexically the verb 'to praise' (halal) denotes cultic praise within the living covenant community, so the silence stated is the cessation of public cultic praise rather than a flat denial of any awareness. The verse is in real tension with conscious-presence readings but does not on its own lexicon establish unconsciousness.

Dan.12.2 · addressed

The 'those sleeping in the dust of the earth' (yshenei admat apha) phrase locates the sleeping in the dust of the earth, naming the burial place. Lexically the sleep here is of those whose bodies lie in dust, awaiting bodily awakening. Whether the entire person sleeps or only the body sleeps while the person continues elsewhere is not adjudicated by the words alone, and either lens can read the verse coherently.

Concordance traversed

G1553, G1736, G0360, G3857, G2859, G0086, G0931, G5590, G2837, G2292, H7585, H3462

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All cited anchors fall outside the 3 John ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published window. The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope for the anchor verses. The Luke 23:43 punctuation dispute is editorial and does not appear as a transmitted variant unit in the apparatus, since early manuscripts carry no punctuation at all. The verdict is therefore not sensitive to any documented variant reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. immediate_conscious_presence, soul_sleep, psychopannychism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

immediate_conscious_presence: for · Reads 2 Corinthians 5:8 'to be out of the body' (ekdemesai ek tou somatos) paired with 'to be at home with the Lord' (endemesai pros ton kyrion) as one continuous transition. Reads Philippians 1:23 'to depart, to break camp' (analsai) bound by 'and' (kai) to 'to be with Christ' (syn Christo einai) as direct presence. Takes Luke 23:43 'today' (semeron) adverbially with the adjacent future 'you will be' (ese). Weights Revelation 6:9-11 'souls' (psychai)-speaking and Luke 16:23 'realm of the dead' (hades)-conscious as confirming post-mortem awareness. Concludes the believing dead are with 'the Lord' (kyrios) immediately upon death, awaiting bodily resurrection at the 'coming, the arrival' (parousia).

soul_sleep: complicates · Reads 'to fall asleep' (koimaomai) applied to dead believers (1 Thessalonians 4:13-15, 1 Corinthians 15:6,18,20) and 'to sleep' (yashen) applied to those in the dust (Daniel 12:2) as describing literal unconsciousness of the whole person. Reads Ecclesiastes 9:5,10 the-dead-know-nothing and Psalm 6:5 / Psalm 115:17 no-remembrance-in-Sheol (the realm of the dead) as flat statements that the dead lack awareness. Repunctuates Luke 23:43 attaching 'today' (semeron) to 'I say' (lego). Reads Revelation 6:9-11 and Luke 16 as figurative apocalyptic and parabolic depictions that do not establish doctrine. Concludes the dead are unconscious until bodily resurrection, at which moment they meet 'the Lord' (kyrios).

intermediate_disembodied_state_undefined: complicates · Reads the New Testament presence-language as real but underspecified about the metaphysics. Notes that the Old Testament 'Sheol, the realm of the dead' (sheol) vocabulary is phenomenological (described from observed appearance, not from inside the experience), the New Testament 'soul' (psyche) language is functional rather than substance-claim, and the words do not by themselves settle whether the interval is experienced as continuous awareness or as compressed transition. Concludes the lexical data affirms presence-with-the-Lord at death but does not foreclose all variant accounts of what awareness looks like in that interval.

Progressive revelation matters because the Old Testament 'Sheol, the realm of the dead' (sheol)-silence formulae are written before the New Testament presence-with-Christ vocabulary that locates believers 'toward the Lord' (pros ton kyrion). Analogia scripturae (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) weighs the converging New Testament epistolary and apocalyptic vocabulary alongside the Old Testament lament-speech, neither erasing the Old Testament tension nor letting it overturn the New Testament direct prepositional phrases of presence.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine what the biblical vocabulary says about the state of believers between bodily death and bodily resurrection, and whether the texts depict conscious presence with the Lord, an interval of unconsciousness, or something the words leave underdetermined.

The original stem both asserts immediate conscious presence and names a rival position, soul sleep, as rejected, which preloads the verdict and frames the alternative as already defeated. The neutralized form poses the lexical question without prejudging it. The verdict above is derived on the original stem after testing the soul-sleep reading and an underdetermined reading in their strongest lexical forms as complicating witnesses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.5.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Phil.1.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.23.43

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eccl.9.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Dan.12.2
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1553
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1736
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2837
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7585
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Flags

ecm-shadow